

Job hunting is now AI vs AI

We're officially in the era of the algorithmic applicant. Having put out hiring ads over the years, I was quite surprised with the rising number of applications over the years, some of which seem too darn perfect.

When you think about it, it's never been easier to apply for a job. Thanks to generative AI, especially tools like ChatGPT, anyone with a browser and a bit of ambition can now whip up a "tailored" resumé that mirrors a job description in seconds. With a few more prompts, they can churn out a bespoke cover letter too. Then rinse and repeat a few dozen times a day, if they wish.

This newfound power has dramatically tilted the job market. On the surface, it seems democratising. But in practice, it's flooding recruiters with a deluge of indistinguishable applications, diluting meaningful engagement in the process. The result? A modern job hunt where the most important skill might no longer be competence, but knowing how to prompt an AI tool effectively.

Once upon a time, applying for a job required care. You'd tweak your CV, labour over a cover letter, and hope the effort would get noticed. Today, generative AI automates that entire process. With one well-written prompt, you can reformat your resumé for ten roles across industries you barely understand.

AI resumé tools don't just rephrase qualifications. Many of them are trained to pick up on the buzzwords and job-specific jargon that Applicant Tracking Systems (ATS) look for. These bots don't rest and they can apply to hundreds of jobs faster than you can refresh your inbox.

It sounds like a gift for job seekers. But the very ease with which one can now submit applications is fuelling what some recruiters call the "applicant tsunami." Jobs that once attracted a few dozen candidates now receive hundreds (if not thousands) of applications in mere hours.

Faced with overwhelming numbers, recruiters are turning to their own set of tools. Automated screening, video interviews powered by machine learning, and even



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game-based assessments are becoming the norm. Entire platforms exist to filter out the noise before a human ever sees a CV.

It's a logical response. But there's an irony here: in trying to stand out from AI-generated applications, candidates now use more AI. From tools that "jailbreak" automated interviews to agents that can play games or simulate human responses, the cycle continues.

We've essentially landed in a world where the first few stages of job applications are no longer human-to-human, rather they're AI vs AI. One tool optimises for the recruiter's system; the other for the candidate's visibility. What started as a productivity boost is evolving into a quiet algorithmic arms race.

Of course, every surge comes with consequences. Not all applications are genuine. Not all resumé reflect actual experience. And in an AI-saturated environment, red flags become harder to spot.

Fake identities are becoming harder to detect in remote-first jobs. Fraudulent candidates can now craft believable digital personas, complete with AI-enhanced CVs, voice simulations, and even doctored credentials. For hiring teams, verification is becoming as important as evaluation.

At the heart of this disruption is a contradiction: AI skills are in demand, but overuse of AI in the hiring process is corroding trust on both sides.

Job seekers feel disheartened when they hear nothing after submitting dozens of applications, often without knowing if anyone saw them. Recruiters, meanwhile, are inundated with lookalike CVs, unsure who's genuinely interested or who's simply running a script.

There's reason to hope that the pendulum will swing back. In time, authenticity might become the most valuable differentiator. But getting there will take some pain.

The market has to adapt to not just the sort of tools being used but in expectations. As with any tech-driven shift, we'll find a balance eventually. But until then, the job hunt is about surviving the system built to evaluate them. And in that system, authenticity might be the one thing that bots can't fake ... yet. **d**